



WATCH OUR
PODCAST



All eyes on it: The captains of the 12 participating nations pose with the T20 World Cup. GETTY IMAGES

A tale of two World Cups

Our correspondent brings **vignettes** from England, where the Women's T20 World Cup is unfolding even as football's World Cup captures the nation's imagination.

P. K. Ajith Kumar
ajithkumar.pk@thehindu.co.in

The Women's T20 World Cup in England has competition. The football World Cup kicked off on the other side of the Atlantic a day earlier. Since England is playing in what is arguably the greatest sporting event on the planet, there is considerable interest across this football-mad nation. Home to the Premier League, England has fans all over the world, including India, where players from Manchester United, Arsenal, Liverpool and Chelsea are

often more familiar to fans than those from local clubs like East Bengal or Kerala Blasters. You will find several fan organisations in places like Kerala supporting major English clubs.

So here in England, you come across fans assembling in pubs to watch World Cup action from the United States, Canada and Mexico.

There are, however, plenty of takers for the Women's T20 World Cup too. I have met people who have driven for hours to watch matches at Edgbaston in Birmingham, for the opening match between England and Sri Lanka, and the India-Pakistan encounter the following day. One

such fan is Hemal Kumar, an avid follower of women's cricket, along with his family and friends. They live in Leicester and are originally from Surat.

"I made plans as soon as the ICC announced the World Cup schedule," Hemal says. "I started following women's cricket closely after Harmanpreet Kaur's 171 not out against Australia in the 2017 World Cup semifinal. I was heartbroken when India lost the final. It was great watching India beat Pakistan here at Edgbaston." Hemal was part of a large crowd made up mostly of people of Indian origin. Pakistan did